small audience. He sings the theme-song from the classic Bollywood film *Awara* and finds that the local musicians on stage immediately play the instrumental accompaniment to the song. Seth notes this is to have a happy consequence the next day when he applies for official permission for his trip to Tibet. Someone who was in the audience the previous evening is present during his application for the enabling permit. They get talking about *Awara* while the official considers the application. The local official knows Bollywood films and is drawn into the discussion, and Seth soon gets his permit.[35]

On a train ride, Seth is engaged in innocent and friendly conversations by curious fellow passengers. He is asked forthrightly about his marital status, a family photograph is examined, and questions are asked about his father's kurta and his mother's bindi. The 1962 war, he is told, was 'an unfortunate incident, the fault of governments, not of peoples, and anyway a very short period of hostility when looked at in the perspective of such a long friendship'. Discussion turns amiably to Raj Kapoor, Seth's job prospects, and India's birth control programme.[36] In Liuyuan, he tries to get a truck ride for the next stage of his journey. A rather comical exchange with a truck driver ensues, with the driver trying to guess Seth's nationality: Mexican, Sri Lankan, Pakistani, Nepalese, Iranian, Russian? He is playfully steered to the right answer. The driver clearly has no picture in his mind of the physical appearance of an Indian – or at least a north Indian. Seth also describes an evening spent with a local official who had served in the army in the 1962 war. You can almost see the rueful headshaking of the man as he recounts: 'A strange task [being a border soldier in 1962]. You couldn't tell where the border was. One day it was here, another day there. We retreated, they [the Indians] occupied, and *vice versa*. We just did what we were told. I'm glad things have improved in our relations.'[37]

On the evening before India's annual Independence Day celebrations, Seth reflects on the two countries. It is 1981, China's extraordinary economic reforms and rise have not yet occurred, yet there is already much to be admired in China's development story: 'One overwhelming fact is that the Chinese have a better system of social care and of distribution than we